struggle to find someone to talk to. They are still limited by stigma and hesitation." Hence initiatives like his.

WHAT AILS THE YOUTH

There was a time when only extreme scenarios like schizophrenia or bipolar disorder warranted a visit to a psychiatrist or therapist. Times, though, have changed, as has the very scope of mental disorders.

India is at a turning point: it has the largest youth demographic in the world—a fifth of the world's young population resides in India. As of 2022, the average age of Indians was 28.7 years, far below the median of 38.4 for China and 48.6 for Japan. But this young population is growing up in circumstances far different from those in which traditional mental health systems evolved in India. "Mental health issues by themselves are not new," says Bengaluru-based clinical psychologist Puroitree Majumdar. "But two things have changed—people are more individualistic and isolated today, and there is significantly more pressure from the environment on how to look, what to eat, where to work." For instance, Majumdar has seen patients suffering from stress simply because there is no clear path to the job they want. And so emerge problems like loneliness or poor self-esteem, which though for generations were considered par for the course, must now be seen as legitimate mental health issues.

Nothing, however, has changed. "If my siblings or I say we are feeling mentally unwell, they [the parents] will react with anger.... They don't understand our minds or its challenges," says Delhi-based Rita Takkar (name changed), 16, who had to take counselling at school for an anxiety disorder. "I used to procrastinate a lot as I was anxious about simple tasks. My parents would think I'm lazy and addressed the procrastination, but not my mental health because the latter they think is for 'crazy people'."

The structure of the modern family has also changed. "Earlier, we were



YOUNG CRUSADERS

YourDOST
Provides online counselling and emotional wellness coaching
www.yourdost.com

LonePack
A peer-to-peer support system to talk about mental health issues
www.lonepack.org

It's Ok To Talk
A safe digital space to share your experiences with others
www.itsoktotalk.in

We The Young
A platform for young people to share their stories of mental health
www.wetheyoung.in

SoulUp
Gives access to a network of peers with whom one can share their emotional challenges
www.soulup.in

Emotions Matter
An NGO that works to spread awareness around mental health and help the marginalised
Instagram: @lightupei

Youth For Mental Health
Advocates for mental health awareness through various campaigns and initiatives
www.youthformentalhealth.org

MindPeers
An app that uses technology to measure people's mental strengths and weaknesses
www.mindpeers.co

Evolve
A mental health app that provides users with personalised, evidence-based counselling and interventions
www.evolveinc.io

BecauseYOU
A mental health community that offers group programmes and workshops for self-discovery
www.becauseyou.in

TheMindClan
Offers a curated list of therapists, support groups, and helplines across India
www.themindclan.com